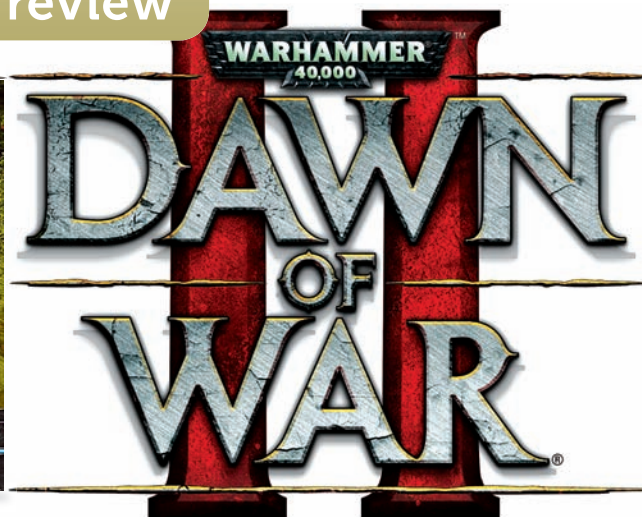




review

Publisher: THQ
Developer: Relic
Score: 8/10



OH TO BE A SPACE MARINE AGAIN

Michael Browne

ESC

Start with a few scattered units, build up your base, churn out units, and upgrade them and Boom! — attack and wipe out all the enemies on the map — typical RTS. However, *Dawn of War 2* (DOW 2) does not follow the standard operating procedure for an RTS game. In fact, the first few minutes had me thinking this was a game with an identity crisis of epic proportions — its no longer an RTS game! It is now what I call an action-RPG.

Yes, the fanatical space marines are still under your control and there are other races to wage war against however this time you will have no base from which to churn out units and you will be restricted to just four squads. Therefore, the single player campaign doesn't have you stomping around the map with terminator squads and predator tanks. Rather you will be in charge of a force commander and up to three specialist space marine squads.

The emphasis here is on squad tactics and manoeuvring your squads in and out of battles as well as using their special abilities with timely precision. Because of the few units under your control you will be seemingly hopelessly outnumbered most of the time. However, each of your squads is a small battle-ready and ultra capable war-machine on its own. While none of the squads are overpowering, the key lies in using their abilities cleverly and in conjunction with the abilities of other squads. For example, the force commander is a powerful *melee* unit capable of bringing much suffering to the enemy in hand-to-hand combat, but if he's tied up with close combat units and ranged units are sniping at him constantly, he will surely fall.

Enter the *scout squad* under your command headed by *Cyrus*, a veteran of many battles and one of the Imperium's most skilled scout masters. This squad can go invisible and can sneak up on a group of enemies and Cyrus can deliver some nasty surprises — stun grenades, fragmentation grenades, charged-up shotgun blasts, demolition charges, or even a long range, instant-kill sniper shot. Then there is the *Tactical Marine squad* — a diverse bunch led by a seasoned campaigner *Tarkus*. These guys are capable of *melee* and ranged attacks and soaking up some damage and therefore, best kept close to the force commander. However, when faced with hordes of enemies, you need something more, something to soften them up at longer ranges. Enter *Avitus*, the leader of the *Devastator Squad*, a group initially equipped with heavy bolters who can

simply open fire in an arc to mow down most enemies at medium ranges. In case your force commander needs a little back-up when getting up close and personal to the baddies, throw in a squad of *assault marines* who are close-combat specialists and another surprise addition to your team — no hints!

Most of the abilities are available in the form of slotted items and only the squad that has such an item slotted into its load-out can use it. Each mission garners more equipment, and sometimes abilities. The single-player campaign is rather long — although it seems quite interesting in the beginning, battling Orks and Eldar by the fifth mission or so you will be bored as things get repetitive. Kill this creature, defend that post — such are the missions and even the locales seem familiar after the first ten missions or so. The story of the campaign revolves around protecting the Space Marine recruiting worlds from rampant Orks who have been stirred up by the stealthy Eldar for unknown motives. As the plot unfolds, you find that a far greater threat in the form of the Tyranids emerge and the Eldar were trying to stop/delay them. The Tyranids are vicious and innumerable foes and they are motivated simply by the need to consume life from all planets, stripping them bare. If you can play through around 80 per cent of the missions you will find things perking up a bit as a couple of the missions are refreshingly different. However, we feel a better job should have been done for the sake of diversity.

Multiplayer is where *DOW 2* shines and you can play the single-player campaign in a co-op style game along with a friend. In fact, once you get into the multiplayer component you'll discover the hidden RTS in *DOW 2* as base and army building is familiar. We quite liked this mix of a single-player action-RPG and multiplayer RTS. As far as graphics go, *DOW 2* looks very nice; although the environments are rather ordinary, the combat effects and squad dynamics are really well done. The audio component is good with decent sound effects although some of the dialogues of squad members (after a mission for example) will become very repetitive. *DOW 2* isn't really heavy on resources, so this is one battle you can fight without cutting edge gear. ■

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Min configuration: 2.0 GHz CPU, 1 GB RAM, GeForce 7 or Radeon x1xxx series GPU with 256 MB VRAM

